



PATIENT HANDOUT

3-day gentle meal plan

Soft-textured meal ideas for an ulcerative colitis flare

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3-day gentle meal plan

Soft-textured meal ideas for an ulcerative colitis flare

Use these meals when a softer approach helps you eat comfortably. Keep other foods you tolerate; there is no need to adopt new restrictions simply because you are flaring. These three days are menu ideas, not a timetable for recovery.[1,3]

For adults with diagnosed ulcerative colitis who can eat and drink and are managing a flare with their healthcare team. This is not a treatment for acute severe colitis or a personalised nutrition prescription. Children, people who are pregnant, and anyone with a stoma, bowel narrowing, recent surgery, or other dietary needs should follow tailored advice.

CHECK THIS FIRST

Before you start

Important: a severe flare needs medical care

A severe flare needs medical assessment, not a diet-only approach. Contact your IBD team promptly about a suspected flare. Seek urgent help for very bad or bloody diarrhoea, fever, a fast heartbeat or dehydration. Call 999 or go to A&E for severe tummy pain, non-stop bleeding, or a lot of blood or large clots.[2,5]

At a glance

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
1	Soft scrambled eggs on white toast	Chicken noodle soup with a soft white roll	Baked cod with smooth mash and carrots
2	Warm semolina with mashed banana	Soft tuna and courgette pasta	Turkey cottage pie
3	Yoghurt and banana with white toast	Soft potato and egg bowl	One-pot chicken and soft white rice

Snacks and drinks

Day	Snacks for today
1	Plain yoghurt (150 g) with a small ripe banana; rice pudding (150 g). Add another snack or larger portions as needed.
2	Cheddar (30 g) with 3 plain crackers; smooth yoghurt (150 g) with 2 tablespoons of tinned peaches, drained and chopped.
3	A glass of milk (200 ml) with 2 plain biscuits; rice pudding (150 g). Choose lactose-free versions only when needed.

Portions are starting points, not a daily calorie target. Add meals, snacks or extra tolerated portions to meet your needs. Smaller, frequent meals may help when appetite is low; do not deliberately under-eat.[3,4]

DAY 1

Day 1

Breakfast | Soft scrambled eggs on white toast

Vegetarian • Simple ingredients

10 minutes total • Serves 1 • Prep 3 minutes • Cook 7 minutes

Gently cooked eggs with lightly toasted white bread. Keep the eggs moist, but fully set rather than runny.

Ingredients

- 2 medium eggs
- 2 slices white bread (about 70 g)
- 2 tablespoons milk, or water
- 1 teaspoon olive oil
- A small pinch of salt, optional

Method

- 1 Beat the eggs with the milk or water. Warm the oil in a non-stick pan over a low heat.
- 2 Add the eggs and stir slowly until fully set, without letting them dry out.
- 3 Lightly toast the bread, or leave it soft if preferred. Spoon over the eggs and serve immediately.

Nutrition: eggs supply protein; bread provides starchy carbohydrate; olive oil adds energy. Adaptation: use your usual milk if tolerated, or lactose-free milk. For a milk-free version, use water and check the bread label.

Allergens: eggs and wheat (gluten); milk if used. Check the bread label for other allergens.

Lunch | Chicken noodle soup with a soft white roll

One pot • Soft texture

25 minutes total • Serves 1 • Prep 5 minutes • Cook 20 minutes

A mild soup with tender chicken, fine noodles and soft carrots, served with bread for a more substantial lunch.

Ingredients

- 100 g skinless chicken breast, cut into small pieces
- 50 g dried fine white noodles
- 50 g carrot, weighed after peeling, finely diced
- 400 ml mild chicken stock, plus extra water if needed
- 1 teaspoon olive oil
- 1 soft white roll (about 50 g)

Method

- 1 Bring the stock to a gentle simmer. Add the carrot and cook for 5 minutes.
- 2 Add the chicken. Simmer for about 10 minutes, then add the noodles and cook according to the packet until soft. Add water if the soup becomes too thick.
- 3 Check the chicken is cooked all the way through and the carrot is very soft. Stir in the olive oil. Serve with the white roll.

Nutrition: chicken supplies protein; noodles and the roll provide starchy carbohydrate. The soup also contributes fluid. Adaptation: use a stock you tolerate. Onion or garlic do not have to be excluded, but an onion- and garlic-free stock is an option when these are known symptom triggers.

Allergens: wheat (gluten); noodles may contain egg. Stock and bread may contain celery, milk, soya or other allergens: check labels.

Dinner | Baked cod with smooth mash and carrots

Oven and hob · Soft texture

35 minutes total · Serves 1 · Prep 10 minutes · Cook 25 minutes

Simply baked fish with creamy-textured potato and well-cooked carrot. No cream is needed.

Ingredients

- 1 boneless cod fillet (about 150 g)
- 300 g potato, weighed after peeling, cut into small pieces
- 75 g carrot, weighed after peeling, sliced
- 50 ml milk, plus more if needed
- 2 teaspoons olive oil
- A small pinch of salt, optional

Method

- 1 Heat the oven to 190°C / 170°C fan. Boil the potato and carrot in separate pans until very soft, about 15-20 minutes.
- 2 Place the cod in a small baking dish with 1 teaspoon oil and a splash of water. Cover with foil and bake for about 15-20 minutes, depending on thickness, until cooked through, opaque and flaking easily. Check for bones.
- 3 Drain the potato and mash with the milk and remaining oil. Mash the carrot separately, or leave it in soft pieces. Serve with the fish.

Nutrition: cod supplies protein; potato provides starchy carbohydrate; milk contributes protein and calcium. Adaptation: use lactose-free milk only if needed. A calcium-fortified soya drink is another option if tolerated. Replace the cod with haddock or another boneless white fish.

Allergens: fish and milk. Soya if using a soya drink.

Serve a smaller amount at a time if that feels easier, then eat more later. A large meal does not have to be finished in one sitting. Use a tolerated milk or yoghurt; lactose-free products are optional, not required for everyone.[1,3]

Fluids: take regular small drinks through the day. With diarrhoea, you may need extra fluid and salts. Ask your pharmacist or IBD team about oral rehydration solution; follow any personal fluid restriction.[5]

DAY 2

Day 2

Breakfast | Warm semolina with mashed banana

Vegetarian · Smooth texture

12 minutes total · Serves 1 · Prep 2 minutes · Cook 10 minutes

A warm, smooth cereal bowl made with milk and a small amount of ripe banana.

Ingredients

- 45 g fine semolina
- 250 ml milk
- Half a small ripe banana (about 50 g peeled)
- Extra milk or water to loosen, if needed

Method

- 1 Warm the milk in a small saucepan over a low heat.
- 2 Gradually whisk in the semolina. Cook gently for 5-10 minutes, following the packet directions, and keep stirring until smooth. Add extra liquid as needed.
- 3 Mash the banana thoroughly and stir it through. Serve warm rather than very hot.

Nutrition: milk supplies protein and calcium; semolina provides starchy carbohydrate. Banana adds some fibre. Adaptation: use lactose-free milk if needed. Semolina contains wheat: for coeliac disease, use a certified gluten-free rice cereal and follow its cooking instructions. Leave out banana if it worsens symptoms.

Allergens: wheat (gluten) and milk. Soya if using a soya alternative.

Lunch | Soft tuna and courgette pasta

Quick lunch · Simple ingredients

20 minutes total · Serves 1 · Prep 5 minutes · Cook 15 minutes

Small pasta shapes with flaked tuna and soft courgette. A little cooking water keeps the dish moist.

Ingredients

- 75 g dried white pasta
- 100 g tinned tuna in spring water, drained weight
- 50 g courgette, peeled and finely diced
- 2 teaspoons olive oil
- 2 tablespoons milk, or extra pasta cooking water

Method

- 1 Cook the pasta according to the packet. Add the courgette for the last 6-8 minutes, extending cooking slightly if needed until both are soft.
- 2 Drain, reserving a little cooking water. Return the pasta and courgette to the pan.
- 3 Flake in the tuna. Add the oil, milk or water, and enough reserved cooking water for a moist texture. Stir over a gentle heat until piping hot throughout.

Nutrition: tuna supplies protein; pasta provides starchy carbohydrate; olive oil adds energy. Adaptation: swap the courgette for very well-cooked peeled carrot. For a fish-free version, use cooked chicken or a tolerated portion of plain tofu; nutrition will differ.

Allergens: fish and wheat (gluten); milk if used. Check the pasta for egg; tofu contains soya.

Dinner | Turkey cottage pie

Comfort food · Soft texture

45 minutes total · Serves 1 · Prep 10 minutes · Cook 35 minutes

A small cottage pie with lean turkey, soft carrot and smooth mashed potato.

Ingredients

- 125 g lean turkey mince
- 250 g potato, weighed after peeling, diced
- 75 g carrot, weighed after peeling, finely diced
- 150 ml mild chicken stock
- 50 ml milk
- 1 teaspoon olive oil
- 1 teaspoon cornflour, mixed with 1 tablespoon cold water

Method

- 1 Heat the oven to 190°C / 170°C fan. Boil the potato until soft, about 15-20 minutes.
- 2 Meanwhile, heat the oil in a pan. Cook the turkey for about 5 minutes, breaking it into small pieces. Add the carrot and stock; simmer for 15 minutes or until the carrot is very soft and the turkey is fully cooked.
- 3 Stir in the cornflour mixture and simmer until lightly thickened. Add a splash of water if needed.
- 4 Drain the potato and mash with the milk. Spoon the turkey mixture into a small ovenproof dish, top with mash and bake for 10-15 minutes until piping hot throughout. Keep the topping soft rather than crisp.

Nutrition: turkey supplies protein; potato provides starchy carbohydrate; milk contributes protein and calcium. Adaptation: use lactose-free milk when needed. Keep the stock mild, but only exclude particular flavourings when they affect your symptoms.

Allergens: milk. Stock may contain celery, wheat (gluten), soya or other allergens: check the label.

Serve a smaller amount at a time if that feels easier, then eat more later. A large meal does not have to be finished in one sitting. Use a tolerated milk or yoghurt; lactose-free products are optional, not required for everyone.[1,3]

Low-energy cooking day: make the pie when you feel able and follow safe chilling and reheating guidance. Check poultry is cooked through; see the practical notes on the final page.[8]

DAY 3

Day 3

Breakfast | Yoghurt and banana with white toast

Vegetarian • Minimal preparation

5 minutes total • Serves 1 • Prep 5 minutes • Cook none, apart from toast

A simple breakfast for a low-energy morning: smooth yoghurt and mashed banana, with bread on the side.

Ingredients

- 170 g plain Greek-style yoghurt
- 1 small ripe banana (about 80 g peeled)
- 2 slices white bread (about 70 g)
- 1 teaspoon butter, optional

Method

- 1 Mash the banana until smooth and stir it into the yoghurt.
- 2 Lightly toast the bread, or leave it soft. Add a little butter if tolerated.
- 3 Serve the toast alongside the yoghurt.

Nutrition: yoghurt supplies protein and calcium; bread and banana provide carbohydrate. Protein varies between yoghurt products. Adaptation: use lactose-free yoghurt if lactose is a problem. A calcium-fortified soya yoghurt is a dairy-free alternative; check its protein content. Use a little stewed peeled apple instead of banana only if you tolerate it.

Allergens: milk and wheat (gluten). Soya if using a soya alternative. Check the bread for other allergens.

Lunch | Soft potato and egg bowl

Vegetarian • Soft texture

25 minutes total • Serves 1 • Prep 5 minutes • Cook 20 minutes

Warm mashed potato and carrot topped with finely chopped, fully cooked egg.

Ingredients

- 2 medium eggs
- 250 g potato, weighed after peeling, diced
- 50 g carrot, weighed after peeling, finely diced
- 40 ml milk, plus more if needed
- 1 teaspoon olive oil

Method

- 1 Boil the potato and carrot until both are very soft, about 15-20 minutes.
- 2 In a separate pan, boil the eggs until the yolks and whites are set, about 10 minutes. Cool under running water, peel and chop finely.
- 3 Drain and mash the vegetables with the milk and olive oil. Fold in the egg, adding a little warm water or milk to keep the bowl moist. Serve immediately.

Nutrition: eggs supply protein; potato provides starchy carbohydrate; milk contributes protein and calcium. Adaptation: use lactose-free milk if needed. For a milk-free version, use a tolerated calcium-fortified soya drink or a little cooking water; nutrition will differ.

Allergens: eggs and milk. Soya if using a soya drink.

Dinner | One-pot chicken and soft white rice

One pot • Soft texture

35 minutes total • Serves 1 • Prep 5 minutes • Cook 30 minutes

Tender chicken and white rice cooked in mild stock, with soft courgette and a loose, spoonable texture.

Ingredients

- 125 g skinless chicken breast, cut into small pieces
- 75 g dried white rice
- 75 g courgette, peeled and finely diced
- 400 ml mild chicken stock, plus extra water if needed
- 2 teaspoons olive oil

Method

- 1 Bring the stock to a simmer. Add the rice and chicken, cover partly and simmer for 10 minutes.
- 2 Add the courgette. Cook for a further 15-20 minutes, stirring regularly and adding water as needed, until the rice is very soft and the chicken is thoroughly cooked.
- 3 Stir in the olive oil. Check the chicken is cooked through before serving. Keep the rice moist, rather than letting it dry out.

Nutrition: chicken supplies protein; rice provides starchy carbohydrate; olive oil adds energy.

Adaptation: use finely diced peeled carrot instead of courgette, adding it at the start. For a meat-free option, use vegetable stock and tolerated plain tofu; nutrition will differ.

Allergens: stock may contain celery, wheat (gluten), milk, soya or other allergens. Check labels; tofu contains soya.

Serve a smaller amount at a time if that feels easier, then eat more later. A large meal does not have to be finished in one sitting. Use a tolerated milk or yoghurt; lactose-free products are optional, not required for everyone.[1,3]

Rice safety: cool leftovers quickly, ideally within 1 hour, refrigerate and use within 24 hours. Reheat only once, until steaming hot throughout.[9]

PRACTICAL NOTES

Using the plan safely

Make it your own

Weights for vegetables are after peeling, and rice, noodles and pasta are weighed dry. Timings are guides and vary with equipment and portion size. Choose familiar foods and follow any allergy advice. Check stock, bread, noodles and dairy-alternative labels each time.

These recipes are not a complete personalised diet. Ask an IBD dietitian for support if you are losing weight, avoiding whole food groups or struggling to eat enough. Plain tofu can replace some meat or fish if tolerated, but the nutrient amounts will change.[3,4]

Food safety

Cook chicken and turkey thoroughly: a clean food thermometer should show 75°C for 30 seconds at the centre, or 70°C for 2 minutes. Keep raw poultry separate from ready-to-eat food. These recipes use fully cooked eggs. Follow any extra advice for medicines that weaken your immune system.[8,9]

For leftover rice, cool quickly, ideally within 1 hour. Keep refrigerated and use within 24 hours; reheat once only, until steaming hot all the way through. Follow product storage instructions for other foods.[9]

About the nutrition sections

Nutrition notes identify the main food sources in each recipe. Numerical calories, protein, carbohydrate, fat and fibre have not been calculated. The recipes are not labelled as nutritionally complete, and ingredient substitutions change their nutritional content.

GO FURTHER

More Support From VanceHealthHub

- **Eating During a Flare and Adding Foods Back:** what to reduce short-term, and how to widen your diet again as symptoms settle
- **Gastro Recipes & Meal Planner:** build your own week from gut-friendly recipes once symptoms are more settled
- **Malnutrition Calculator:** track unintentional weight change to raise with a dietitian or GP
- **Health Record:** log symptoms and any foods you notice a pattern with

This plan is a starting point, not individual dietary advice. None of these replace your GP, gastroenterologist or dietitian, and nothing on VanceHealthHub should be used to diagnose or treat a condition.

REFERENCES

Sources and further reading

Sources accessed 11 September 2026. General information, not a substitute for advice from your own healthcare team.

1. Crohn's & Colitis UK. Food.
2. NHS. Ulcerative colitis: when to get medical help.
3. University College London Hospitals NHS Foundation Trust. Ulcerative Colitis: My Diet During a Flare Up.
4. Crohn's & Colitis Foundation. What Should I Eat with Crohn's or Colitis?
5. Crohn's & Colitis UK. Dehydration.
8. Food Standards Agency. Cooking your food.
9. Food Standards Agency. Home food fact checker: rice and eggs.

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